

Synopsis of the Books of the Bible

1 Timothy

John Nelson Darby (1800-1882)

Public domain edition

1 TIMOTHY.

The Epistles to Timothy and Titus have naturally a peculiar bearing and character, being addressed to sons deputed by the apostle to act in his name, or for the churches during his absence. Their appeal to us is none the less direct on this account, because not only instruct us with regard to the state of the Church and the pastoral care which the apostle bestowed but the line of conduct in which Timothy is charged to lead the faithful is that which the faithful ought always to follow. Nevertheless to confound directions given to Timothy and Titus, with the Epistle addressed immediately to the faithful, would be to create confusion upon ministry in its best sense. A great part of this First Epistle to Timothy requires but little development; not because it is without importance, but because it contains directions—so plain

practical exhortations which would only be obscured their force and point taken away, by attempting to enlarge upon them.

On the other hand some general principles of great importance for the position of the Church in general are contained in this epistle. ;

God assumes here, in a peculiar way, the character of a Saviour-God with regard to the world: a principle of great importance in all that concerns our converse:

in the world, and our intercourse with men. We represent, in our religious character, a God of love. This was not the case in Judaism. He was, indeed, the same God; but there He took the character of a Lawgiver. All were indeed to come to His temple, according to the declaration of the prophets, and His temple was open to them ; but He did not characterize Himself as a Saviour-God for all. In Titus we find the same expression.

In these confidential communications to his dear children in the faith and companions in the work we can understand that the apostle would clearly establish the great principles on which the administration committed to him rested. That all men were the objects of God's dealing in grace was the general basis on which this administration was founded—that the character of God towards the world was that of a Saviour. (Compare 2 Cor. v.) The law had its place and it still has it, as the apostle shews. But the sovereign mercy of God was the starting point of all that the apostle had to declare. This thought, this spirit, was to govern the worship even of believers. Details follow. Notwithstanding this love to the world, there was upon the earth a Church of the living God, the pillar and support of the truth, and the witness to it on earth. The person of Christ, and all that concerns Him, is the subject of its testimony, the foundation of its existence, and the object of its faith. 'This faith would be assailed in the last days by the enemy, who, under the pretence of sanctity, would set himself up against God the Creator and Preserver of all men, and of believers in particular. Directions for the walk of the Church compose the remainder of the epistle.

Conduct suitable to all is set before Timothy, to men: him, as well as ourselves, understand that which becometh the Church of God. We will now look more closely into the contents of this epistle. ‘

From its commencement the apostle designates God as the Saviour-God. Paul is the apostle of Jesus Christ by the commandment of God our Saviour. The Lord Jesus Christ is the confidence and the hope of the soul. 2»

We observe also that the apostle's wish differs from that which he expresses when addressing a church; "Grace, mercy," he says, "and peace." He does not say "mercy" to the churches, which stand before as such, in consequence of the mercy shewn them, and which (however low their condition might be) are viewed as churches according to the nature in which they live by the Spirit, in which there is no question of mercy because that nature is itself of God. Grace and peace are that which they are to enjoy on the part of God. But when an individual is in question, whatever his piety or faithfulness may be, he is both flesh and spirit, his career has yet in part at least to be provided for, having always need of mercy. Therefore the apostle wishes it Timothy as well as to Titus. In the case of Phileas he adds "the church in thy house," and his wish as therefore no longer the personal form. But with Timothy and Titus it is the apostle's intimacy with his beloved fellow-labourers. He knew how much they needed mercy. It was his own resource, that which he had experienced for the comfort of his own soul, a

The special object for which Paul had left Timothy at Ephesus when he went into Macedonia was that he

might watch over the doctrine which was taught; but, being there, he gives him directions for the interior order of the Church. The evil which the enemy sought to introduce, with regard to doctrine, had a twofold character: fables of human imagination, and the introduction of the law into Christianity. As to the former, it was pure evil and edified no one. The apostle does not here say much about it; he forewarned them of the evil; and the faith of the Church at Ephesus was sound enough to allow him to treat the whole system as mere fables and genealogies. The Spirit gave warning, that in later times it would have more disastrous consequences; but at present there was only need to guard the faithful from it as that which was worthless. Timothy was charged by the apostle to attend to this.

But that which is committed to us in Christianity, as service, is always, both in its object and its character, at the height of the eternal principles of God, and belongs to the foundation of our moral relations with Him.

The object of Paul's mandate is the love of a pure heart, and faith unfeigned; and never the subtleties of argument or of human imagination. This is a sure token for souls that are sound in the faith, and guided by the Spirit of God. Some had forsaken these great landmarks of Christianity, turning aside to vain discussions. And here we again find those same corrupters of Christianity, who, after having rejected the Saviour, sowed the apostle's path with thorns—Judaizing teachers. They desired to inculcate the law. The human mind is adequate to this.

Now we see here the way in which one who is at the

height of the truth of God can put everything in its place. Paul treats the produce of human imagination as mere fables; but the law was of God, and could be useful if rightly employed. It was of great service to condemn, to judge evil, to slay—to shew the judgment of God against every wrong thing forbidden by gospel, which revealed the glory of the blessed God's glory which tolerated no evil, and which had been committed to the apostle. It could be used to act upon conscience in this way, but it did not build up righteousness; and if any were under the law, they were under the curse. As a sword for the conscience, it might be used. But grace alone is the source of our peace and the stay of our souls. These two systems and their respective places are sententia in verses 5—17, which form a kind of parenthesis, the apostle resuming his

address to Timothy in verse 18. The use of the law is explained verses 8—13. The apostle in a certain sense lowers it here, while acknowledging its utility in its place, as the weapon of righteousness for condemnation; and contrasts it with the gospel which is connected with the glory of God Himself, this gospel proclaims, as the law is connected with wickedness which it condemns. Having spoken of the gospel of the glory which has been committed to him, the apostle turns to the sovereign grace that had brought him into the knowledge of glory, which is the testimony to the efficacy of the work of grace. “Let us give thanks,” he says, “to Jesus Christ our Lord who hath counted me faithful, putting me into his

ministry, who was before a blasphemer and a persecutor, and injurious.” This, indeed, was grace.

‘The apostle speaks of two things in his conversion: the one, how God could have compassion on him in such a state—he was in ignorance; the other, the purpose of God that the apostle should be a pattern of grace to all. That he was in ignorance and unbelief, although a condition which made mercy possible (for had he been an enemy, knowing and willing it, while acquainted with the grace of the gospel, it would have been impossible), yet that condition was no excuse for his sin; he puts pure and perfect grace forward, as having abounded in his case—he was the chief of sinners. This, indeed, was true. The high priests had resisted the Holy Ghost to the uttermost. Paul had joined them in it; but he was ‘not satisfied with that. He desired to be the active enemy of the faith, wherever it existed, and to destroy the name of Jesus. He had done much at Jerusalem, but he wished to satiate his hatred even in foreign cities. We know his history in the Acts. The living expression of Jewish resistance to grace, he was also among men ‘the expression of human enmity to Him whom God ‘would glorify. Grace was greater than the sin, the patience of God more perfect than the perseverance of ‘man’s hostility. The latter was limited by man’s impotence, the former has no limit in the nature of God but ‘that of His own sovereign will. Guilty as man may be, ‘his sin cannot so reach God as to disturb the independent action of His nature or change His purposes. He ‘was pleased to shew forth in Paul a pattern of the sovereign reign of that grace and perfect goodness—to the Jews I.

hereafter, who as a nation will be in Saul’s condition to all men, as the enemies of God and by nature full of wrath. The chief, the most active, the most inveterate of enemies was the best and most powerful of witnesses that the grace of God abounded over sin, and that the work of Christ was perfect to put it away. See “Unto God”—being such in His nature, and having the development of all the ages in His counsels—“until the only God, invisible, incorruptible,” he sets praise and all glory. Such was the foundation of his ministry in contrast with the law. It was founded on the revelation of grace; but it was a revelation connected with the experience of its application to his own case. Peter, guilty of denying a living Saviour, could speak to the Jews of grace that met their case, which was his own; Paul, formerly the enemy of a glorified Jesus and the resister of the Holy Ghost, could testify that rose above even that state of sinfulness, above that could flow from human nature; grace that opened the door to the Gentiles according to God’s own counsel when the Jews had rejected everything, substituting the heavenly Church for them; grace, that sufficed for the future admission of that guilty nation to better privileges than those which they had forfeited. Such was the call of this apostle, such his mission. Having shewn the opposition between that which was committed to him and the law (while confirming the latter), he resumes his address to Timothy in that which refers to the details of his mission among the Ephesians. At the end of chapter i. he commits the charge to him—sends him his mandate. The term he uses

relates to verses 3 and 5. He had left Timothy at Ephesus in order to command some persons there not to teach other doctrines than the truths of the gospel. Now the end of the command, of this evangelical commission, was love flowing from a pure heart and a good conscience and faith unfeigned. For the gospel, while revealing the marvellous counsels of God, maintains the great eternal principles of His nature. It is this which distinguishes truth from the lofty pretensions of heretical imaginations ; it requires that man should be in relationship with God really in heart and in truth, according to those principles. And this commission the apostle now entrusted to Timothy, his own son in the faith. He was to maintain it with an authority that had its basis in divine testimony, but which he held formally from the apostle, who appointed him to it; not merely of his own accord, but according to prophecies which had pointed him out for this purpose, and which were a means of strength to him in the conflict he was thus brought into, The conditions of victory were in accordance with the nature of the commission. He was to keep the faith and a good conscience, Now faith here is the doctrine of Christianity; yet not merely as doctrine, but as that which the soul held between itself and God, as coming from Him. He had to maintain the truth, the christian doctrine ; but to hold it as so revealed by God Himself to the soul that it should be the truth. The light should possess, with well-defined outlines, the authority of God.

It was the faith, that which God had revealed, received with certainty as such—as the truth.

But, to be in communion with God, the conscience

I.

must be good, must be pure; and if we are not in communion with God, we cannot have the strength would maintain us in the faith, that would enable persevere in the profession of the truth, as God g to us. Satan has then a hold upon us, and if the intellect of one in this state is active, he falls into b The loss of a good conscience opens the door to § because it deprives us of communion with God; an active mind, under Satan's influence, invents idea stead of confessing the truth of God. The apostle the fruit of this state as “ blasphemies ;” the will of m is at work, and the higher the subject, the more. unbridled will, possessed by the enemy, goes astray, and exalts itself against God and against the subjection of the whole mind to the obedience of Christ, to the authority of the revelation of God.

The apostle had delivered up two persons of this character to Satan—that is to say, outwardly. They already deceived by him, they were not under his minion as having power to torment and make suffer. For in the Church (when in its normal state Satan has no power of that kind. It is guarded it, being the dwelling place of the Holy Ghost, and protected by God, and by the power of Christ. Satan tempts us individually; but he has no right over members of the Church as such. They are within, weak as they may be, Satan cannot enter there. may be delivered to him for their good. This may place at all times—witness the history of Job. But the Church ought to have the knowledge, and be guardian and instrument, of the accomplishment of

dealings of God with His own. Within the Church is the Holy Ghost; God dwells in it as His house by the Spirit. Without is the world of which Satan is the prince. The apostle, by the power bestowed on him,* delivered these two men into the power of the enemy deprived them of the shelter they had enjoyed. They had listened to the enemy—had been his instruments. It was not in the Church, with

members of Christ, that this should have taken place. They must be made to feel what he was to whom they had given ear. God thus made use of Satan himself as a rod for the good of His rebellious children, Satan should instruct them, through the pains he would make them suffer, of whatever kind it might be, whether anguish of soul or of body, in order that their will might be broken and brought into subjection to God. Solemn discipline! Marvellous power in the hands of man! but a proof that the love of God can order all things for the purpose of delivering a soul and bringing it to Himself.

The apostle proceeds to give instructions, founded on the great principles which he had established—on grace. The Jewish spirit might look on Gentile kings as enemies, and on Gentiles in general as unworthy of divine favour. The persecution of which Christians were the object gave the flesh occasion to nourish these dis-

* We must not confound this act of power with discipline, which is the act of the assembly, and its formal duty. In 1 Corinthians v. the apostle joins the assembly to himself in this act of power, but he delivered with the power of Christ. The duty of the assembly is stated there in verse 18. As to the

saints' or Church's part, when God has exercised discipline, see 1 John v. 16; James v. 14, 15.

positions, and to enter into the spirit of the law. rises above all these thoughts—all these feelings of the heart. It teaches us to think of all men with love. We belong to a Saviour-God, who acts in the gospel toward: all men with love. Especially were they to pray for kings, and those who had high places in the world, that God would dispose their hearts to allow us to live in peace and quietness in all honesty. This was wellpleasing to a Saviour-God, who was willing that all men

should be saved, and be brought to know the truth. The subject here is not the counsels of God, but His dealings with men under the gospel. He acts in grace. It is the acceptable time—the day of salvation. He opens the door through the blood of Christ, and proclaims pe

done; His character fully glorified with regard to sin, If they refuse to come, that is the will of man, T God will fulfil His counsels after all makes no ch in His dealings, nor in the responsibility of men.

have love to proclaim to all—in the spirit of love in + ways towards them. The distinction between Jew and Gentile totally disappears here. There is one God, and one Mediator between God and men, a Man, Christ Jesus. These are the two great truths which form the basis of all true religion. Judaism had already been this revelation and testimony in the world of the first ; there was one only God. This remains eternally true, but did not suffice to bring men into relationship with God With regard to men He abode within the veil in the darkness which shrouded His majesty. Christian while fully revealing the one God, presents the second

truth: there is one Mediator between God and men. There is one, and there is but one. It is as true that there is but one Mediator as that there is but one God. This is the great and distinctive truth of Christianity.

Two things here characterize the Mediator. He is a man; He gave Himself a ransom for all. The time for this testimony was ordered of God.

Precious truth! We are in weakness, we are guilty, we could not bring ourselves near to God. We needed a Mediator, who, while maintaining the glory of God, should put us into such a position, that He could present us to God in righteousness, according to that | glory. Christ gave Himself as a ransom. But He must | be a man, in order to suffer for men, and to represent men. And this He was. But this is not all. We are weak—here, where we are to receive the revelation of | God ; and weak, with regard to the use of our resources | in God, and our communion with Him—even when our guilt is blotted out. And in our weakness to receive the revelation of God, Christ has revealed God, and all that | He is in His own person, in all the circumstances wherein man could have need either in body or in soul. He came down into the lowest depths, in order that there should , be none, even of the most wretched, who could not feel that God in His goodness was near him, and was | entirely accessible to him—come down to Him—His love finding its occasion in misery; and that there was | no need to which He was not present, which He could | not meet,

It is thus that He made Himself known on earth; and now that He is on high, He is still the same. He does

not forget His human experiences: they are perpetuated by His divine power, in the sympathizing feelings of . humanity, according to the energy of that divine which was their source and their motive power, still a man, in glory, and in divine perfection, divinity imparts the strength of its love to His humar but does not set aside the latter. Nothing could re such a Mediator as this; nothing could equal the ness, the knowledge of the human heart, the syx the experience of need. In the measure which diy could give to what He did, and in the strength of its love, He came down, took part in all the sorrows of humanity, and entered into all the circumstances in which the human heart could be, and was wou oppressed, and discouraged, bowing down under the No tenderness, no power of sympathy, no humanity. His; no human heart that can so understand, so with us, whatever the burden may be that oppresses | heart of man. It is the Man, the Christ Jesus, w our Mediator; none so near, none who has come ¢ so low, and entered with divine power into the need, all the need, of man. The conscience is purified by work, the heart relieved by that which He was, and _which He is for ever. | There is but One: to think of another would b snatch from Him His glory, and from us our perfect consolation. His coming from on high, His divine nature, His death, His life as man in heaven, all point Him out as the one and only Mediator. rh) \ But there is another aspect of this truth, and of the fact that He isa man. It is, that He is not merely a

1 TIMOTHY. 155

Mediator, as a Priest upon His throne, between Israel and the Lord; not simply the Messiah, in order to place Tsrael in relationship with their God, but a Man between God and men. It is according to the eternal nature of God Himself, and to the need of men in His presence, It was of these truths, eternal and of universal bearing, that Paul was the herald and the apostle.

Possessing a character that belongs to all ages, and that goes beyond them, all these facts had their time to be revealed.

Every limited and particular means dependent on man's use of them had been tried with men; and now

' the necessary foundations of their relationship with God

had to be set forth, and the Gentiles were to hear the testimony of grace; and such was the apostle's testimony, "a teacher of the Gentiles in the faith and in the truth."

Paul has plainly now laid the foundations, and he

proceeds therefore to details. Men were to pray everywhere, lifting up pure hands, without wrath, and without vain human reasonings. Women were to walk in modesty, adorned with good works, and to learn in silence. A woman was forbidden to teach or to exercise authority over men; she was to abide in quietness and silence. _ The reason given for this is remarkable, and shews how, in our relations with God, everything depends on the original starting-point. In innocence Adam had the first place; in sin, Eve. It was Eve who, being deceived, brought in transgression. Adam was not deceived, guilty as he was of disobeying God. United to Ik,

his wife, he followed her, not deceived by the enemy, but weak through his affection. (Without the wake was this which the second Adam did in grace;

walking in modesty, with faith and love and so she shall be delivered in the hour of her trial; and which bears the stamp of judgment shall be an omen: of the mercy and succour of God.- , The apostle next points out to Timothy the qualities necessary for a bishop or a deacon, as well as for the wife of the latter.* He supposes here that there were some who desired to undertake this work. It was a good work. To care for souls, and have a vigilant eye upon the walk of believers; to watch over them, order that the members of Christ should answer to love, and lose no Christian privilege; to do this by maintaining that happy order and that precious unity which were realized at that time, and to protect flock of the Lord against the ravaging wolves that were seeking to invade it: this, indeed, was valuable work and he on whose heart the Lord had thus laid the burden of His people might well desire to undertake it. The apostle felt this: it was a true and faithful saying; that certain qualities were needed to make any one fit for

* So it would read in English; but I see no reason why *yoivaixas* should not apply to the elders' wives. It runs thus: "In like manner [the] deacons. In like manner [their] wives." See however remarks in next page.

such a charge. Gifts are not included among them, unless the being "apt to teach" might be so considered; but even this is presented as a quality—the man must have *apiness** for it—not as a gift. Power to use truth with others was very useful in fulfilling his charge, without saying at all that he taught publicly in the assembly. The essential thing was that which gave moral weight.

Timothy was not left at Ephesus to appoint elders; but these were the qualities necessary to a bishop, and Paul exhorts him to be watchful on this point.

It is not needful to enter into the detail of these qualities; they are plain enough, as well as those required for a deacon,

We see what was the subject of the condemnation of the devil: he exalted himself at the thought of his own importance. (Compare Ezek. xxviii.) The snare of the devil is another thing. If a man is not of good report, he will yield somewhere to the enemy, because he will not dare to withstand him boldly.

It will be noticed that the apostle speaks of the wives of deacons, and not those of bishopst (except to say that these must be the husbands of one wife only). Bishops had a charge, in which they were occupied with souls and exercised authority in the Church, in which women were not to act. Deacons were necessarily occupied with family details and circumstances. In these women

might well be concerned and often very useful. In the

spiritual cares of elders they had nothing todo. It was

* Some translate this word, “ ready to learn.” + But see last note but one. Itt.

‘of the highest importance for us, with regard 4

requisite, therefore, that the wives of deacons s ou! possess qualities which would cause their husband respected, and, at the same time, guard themselves frof becoming busybodies and tale-bearers. BN: Faithfulness in the charge of a deacon—the exercis of which, in fact, is a matter of the greatest d and requires much christian love and patiencemeans of acquiring strength in the work of Stephen and Philip are examples of this: their s powers soon carried them beyond their service as ¢ What was the Church in those happy days?which, surely, it always is in the sight of God; but in fact, when love displayed itself in an order maint by the energy of the Holy Ghost, and when the on of the entire body developed itself in the action of al its members, it was the house of God. Thank | it is so always! Yet what a difference since then practical condition ! \ But let us here examine the character which the apos gives to the Church on earth. He wrote, hoping soon 1 come; but in ordér that, in case he might tarry — Timothy should know how to conduct himself. He th tells us what the Church is. = In the first place it is the house of God. God dwel

truth is important. It gives a character to the Ck

responsibility. It is not a vague thing, composed of the dead, of the living—a thing which we know not wher

to find, because one part of it is alive on the earth and another part consists of souls in heaven. It is the house of God here below, in which we have to behave (whatever other position we may hold) in a manner that becomes the house of God. God dwells in the Church upon earth. We cannot too earnestly remember this fact. Whatever would bring confusion into the presentation of this truth, through the idea that some are dead and that the whole Church is not here, comes from the enemy, and is in opposition to the word. The Church viewed as subsisting on earth, is the house of God.

In the second place it is the assembly of the living God. God, in whom is the power of life, in contrast with men and with dead idols, has an assembly not of the world, having set it apart for Himself. It is not a nation like Israel. That people were the assembly of ‘God in the wilderness. The Church is now the assembly of the living God.

Tn the third place it is the pillar and support of the truth. Christ on earth was the Truth. (He is so always, ‘but He was so on earth.) He is now hidden in God. The Church is not the truth: the word of God is the truth. His word is truth. Truth exists before the ‘Church ; it is faith in the truth which gathers the Church together. But the Church is that which maintains the troth on earth. When the Church is

gone, men will be given up to a strong delusion.

It may be that there is only a little remnant of those

that call themselves Christians who maintain the word

‘of truth; but it is not the less true that the Church as long as it remains here below—is the only witness for It.

= = eee ie nail Se SS

. truth. Authority is not the question here, but the

the truth upon the earth. It is God’s witness to present the truth before men. At the end, that which God as such will be the feeble flock at Philadelphia; and then, that which is in the responsible position of being the Church (Laodicea) will be spued out of the mouth of Christ, who Himself takes the character of Amen, the faithful and true Witness, But the Church, as planted by God on the earth, is the pillar and support of the

tenance and presentation of the truth. That which not maintain and present the truth is not the Church whom God understands it.

The presence then of the living God, and the profession of the truth, are the characteristics of the house of God. Wherever this assembly of the living God wherever the truth is, there is this house.*

The mystery of piety, which lies at the very centre of what the Church maintains before the world, is and relates essentially to the person of Christ. The apostle naturally does not here develop all the different parts of the truth, but that which is the living centre: the whole—that which is essential to the relations between God and men.

God has been manifested in the flesh; marvellous truth, in fact! There, where all is concentrated

* Thus, in order to judge what the Church is, we must know and be able to distinguish the truth and the living God. [1] this which the apostle says with regard to the individual, ‘ Spirit is truth.” These are the cardinal points with regard to unbelief and faith, the truth and the Spirit; and the word of God is the truth. p

in the nature of him in whom all this sin and all this confusion are introduced, the Centre of all blessing, He who is Light itself, He who as the Light puts everything morally in its place, and who, by the fact of His presence, shews that love is above everything, God who is love has been manifest in the flesh. Where sin was, there was love above the sin. Man, who is the slave of evil, sees here in his own nature the source and the power of all good. In the centre of evil and of weakness, in human nature, God Himself has been manifested. Was there then evil in Him who was such? Did He undergo the lot of the common bondage? By no means. Truly in the same circumstances, in the same nature, He proved superior to all evil, perfect in all respects. The absence of all sin was made evident by the power of the Holy Ghost during His whole life (if men had been able to discern it, and, in fact, it was manifest to the conscience of every man, for He was pure light shining upon all), and with power by the resurrection. (Compare Rom. i. 4.)

Thus God was made visible to the angels, was preached to the Gentiles (not merely the God of the Jews), became the object of faith in the world (it was not the manifestation of visible power, claiming His rights and His glory), and at last took a place on high in the glory whence He had descended. It is thus that God is known in the Church, according to the truth. There is no truth outside the maintenance of this revelation of the person of Christ.

It is worthy of notice, that in this epistle, and even in the second, the apostle speaks nowhere of the relation- VOL, V. III. M

ship of Christians with God as His children, o

privileges of children, or of that which is known wit in the intimacy of the family. He speaks of tra that are essential as testimony before the world; t which the Church is externally, that which it is as 1 witness of God towards men. It is the house of the assembly of the living God, the pillar and s of the truth: that which it is as responsible in

for testimony, answers to this. It is the grand e: truth on which all relation between God and m founded, by means of which God has to do with m Therefore, also, he says previously, "There is but on God, and one Mediator between God and men, the 1 Jesus the Christ." We have not here the privileges of children, nor th heavenly bride of Christ, but the foundation of G relations with all men. Thus the Father is not na ' nor even the Spirit, except here in connection wit! nt Lord's person, as the justification of His testimony, . It is God, the Mediator, and man, and the Church as th vessel and depositary of this truth of the testimor God; or else evil spirits turning men away fron faith. This deserves all attention. y Not only, as we haye seen elsewhere, the testimo the grace of the gospel maintains the great eternal ciples of the nature and glory of God, and His rel: according to that glory, with men; but even in the the apostle takes that the Church may be cared guarded, during his absence, from the assaults of the

enemy, and from disorders and improprieties within ; it is not of its internal privileges that he speaks. God is set before us, and the Lord Jesus Christ. God, in the majesty of His immutable truth, in His relations with men as such, and in the revelation of Himself in the flesh—God was in Christ, reconciling the world; dwelling in the Church, in order that it should present and maintain the truth before the world; the truth (as we have seen) with regard to Christ, of the revelation of God in Him. God desires to be in relation with men: it is thus that He accomplishes it. The Church maintains the rights of the Creator and Saviour-God on the earth. The Church itself must be maintained in moral order, that it may confront the enemy who is in the world, and be able to sustain this testimony.

_ But there would be some who departed from the faith, from this knowledge of the one Creator and Saviour- God—He who was manifested in the flesh. They would attack precisely these points which we have named. It might be that they would pretend to carry the idea of christian privileges farther than all others had done, as well as that of profound knowledge of God; but they would sin against first principles, against the faith which connected the Saviour-God revealed in Christianity with the one only Creator-God. According to Christianity, the eternal God had not only created the world but had revealed Himself in Christ. These apostates, "bringing in doctrines of devils, would seek to deny that it was this one and only God of nature who had mani- - fested Himself in grace. Seduced by demons, and their consciences being seared, they forbade that which God Iv.

had established in creation, that which He had gi

holiness which they preached, and relationship more exalted God, were not consistent with such custo; Forsaking the real and practical holiness of comm' with God, and of His commandments by Christ, created a false sanctity for themselves, which denied tha which God had ordained from the beginning, and exalted themselves against the authority of Him had ordained it, as though He was an imperfect or perhaps evil being. Thus the restraint of the fear of God was lost, the door opened to licence and dissoluteness. Spirit of God warned the Church of this, and the ful apostle communicates it to Timothy, and him puts the faithful on their guard. He does therefore speak of privilege. Faithful to the g) God, he returns to the first principles of His glory, maintains the incontestable rights of the one and God; faithful to God, not making boast of his k ledge, but seeking in love to guard the Church fro departure from God. We must not confound the few here who forsa' faith with the general apostasy of 2 Thessalk Here a few depart from the truth, seduced by de: and the Church still subsists to be guarded from the invasion of these hurtful principles. Quite an th thing is the general apostasy, and the manifestatic the man of sin, which is not mentioned here at all. Here we have the faithfulness which repels error by truth, reminding the brethren of the latter, in order that

they may not be seduced. There it is the manifestation of the one who sits in the temple of God, and who is destroyed by the brightness of the Lord's presence. Here, all that had to be done was to recall in simplicity the goodness of the Creator, and that His gifts, received with thanksgiving, were always good, and not to be refused : not, assuredly, that they were to use them for the gratification of their lusts, but as sanctified by the word of God, which revealed this, and by prayer, which connects us with God in using them. They were to be received as from Him, as the gift of His hand; and they were sanctified, as is the case with everything that comes from Him, and bears the stamp of His will and His goodness. Here (although in other circumstances it has gone much farther) the monastic principle, in the heart and in form, is fully judged; however sincere any individual may be who seeks to follow it in order to honour God. God does not withdraw the gifts on which man, so to speak, has seized by his will; but his use of them, being the gratification of his will and lusts, is now as received from God by His will in thankfulness, and owning Him.

_ This in fact the apostle shews in that which follows. By teaching thus Timothy should be a good servant of desus Christ, nourished in the truth: bodily exercises profited little, but godliness much—both here below and for eternity. It is for this doctrine of God—true and _ worthy of all acceptance—that the apostle laboured and _ suffered reproach ; because he had faith in the living God, ners by His providence and by His supreme power,* * Compare Matthew x, ¥.

governed, preserved, and took care of all men, and especially of those that believed. It was this same God, Creator, and Saviour, in whom he trusted labouring for the Lord. 'Timothy was to teach this and enforce it with authority. n

Afterwards, in connection with this authoritativ struction, the apostle speaks of the person and po: of Timothy himself. He was young, but he wi maintain his place, and gain by his conduct that wei; which years did not yet give him. He was to be a example to the believers, and occupy himself, till aul came, with reading, exhortation, and instruction. over in his case God had given a special prep for his work;

he was not to forget or neglect it. A gift had been imparted to him: God had pointed him out to this end, by prophecy; and this in testimony from God, to which the operation of power was united, had been accompanied by the same testimony from man, i.e., that of the elders among Christians. (Compare 'dt xiii. 1—8.)

Thus all things concurred to strengthen Timothy his service, and in the authority that he exercised a moment in place of the apostle. He should have presented the weight of an irreproachable conduct, would have its influence over hearts and consciences but he was inwardly strengthened by the conscience of having been formally set apart by God for the gift of God had been imparted to him, sanction of all that had weight in the Church "had laid, as a seal, upon him. Thus strengthened, he was to devote himself to the things of the Lord in such a man-

1 TIMOTHY. 167

ner, that his progress should be evident to all men—a demonstration of his communion with the Lord. At the same time he was to take heed to himself and to the doctrine, and that continually, which should be the means of salvation both to himself and to those who heard him. Having thus considered the labourer, the apostle returns to the details of the work, in which Timothy was to display his diligence and watchful care. Everywhere here the subject is that which is suitable outwardly to an upright walk, that which is seemly, whether with regard to the position of individuals, or with respect to the world. The apostle speaks of elders; of widows, of that which is becoming for younger widows; of the honour due to faithful elders, those among them especially who were teachers also. There is nothing inward, nothing of the soul's relationships to God; but everything refers to the public testimony which suited the position of men in this world before God. It is important to remark this, that although our joy lies in our heavenly privileges, in our communion, yet we can never with impunity neglect ordinary duties or moral proprieties ; we must take knowledge of the practical dangers that would beset us, owing to that which the flesh is, We may notice that provision was made for all widows who had no relatives able to maintain them ; and also that there were elders who did not teach, — Against an elder Timothy was not to receive an accusation, unless there were two or three witnesses. —All this bears testimony to the fact, that the apostle gave these directions with a view to outward order; for — the maintenance of that which is respectable in the eyes of

of all, and of respect for all that ought to be respected At the same time Timothy was to be careful not to give by the laying on of hands his sanction to any who did not offer moral guarantees that, in the place he had taken, he deserved this mark of respect from others. It would be, on Timothy's part, to become partaker in the sins of which such a one might be guilty. He was not to lay hands hastily on any one

Some men's sins were open, and proclaimed before hand the judgment that awaited them. The sins of others were hidden: they would find them again at great day. But this was a reason why he should « nothing in his charge with precipitation; he was to keep himself pure. <s

Timothy's habitual temperance is here seen : weak in body, the apostle recommends him to use his liberty taking a little wine—a pleasing instance of how to pass have here a proof of the habits of this faithful servant The Spirit shews us how carefully he kept himself from exciting or satisfying his passions in the least thing at the same time that there is perfect liberty to use every thing that is good when there is a true reason for

and also the apostle's tender interest in his fellow-labourer in the gospel. It is a little parenthesis attached to expression, "be not a partaker of other men's sins," it has great beauty. This affectionate care came from the apostle; he desired holiness in his representative but he well knew how to respect Timothy, and to maintain the decorum which he had enjoined, and to express his heartfelt tenderness, The 24th verse is connected with the 22nd. ' "

The 2 apostle then goes equally into detail with regard to slaves. They were to respect their masters, in order that the doctrine of the Lord should not be blasphemed. If the masters were believers, there was naturally equality, for they were one in Christ, and thence - (for the flesh is crafty): there the servants not treat their masters with the respect due to them, The apostle guards against this abuse of Christian kind of the just intimacy and confidence which ought

to be, by treating him with more love and with the respect necessary that the apostle should be firm. All instruction—all refusal to receive the wholesome of Christian doctrine, the words of Christ and the Holy Spirit which is according to practical godliness—proceed from the flesh, from human pride in those who take advantage of godliness, and make it a means of gain. From such persons Timothy was to turn. Godliness was indeed gain, if they were contented at they had; and the Christian, who does not cling to this world, if he has food and raiment, ought content therewith. He brought nothing into this world, and will certainly carry nothing out of it. And of money is a root of all sorts of evil. Seduced covetousness, some had wandered away from the faith, and had pierced their hearts with sorrow. the desire to be rich was the path of snares and temptations, of foolish and hurtful lusts. Timothy was to flee from them.

these things, as a man of God, This is always the thought here: he was in the world on the part of he represented Him for his part in the work. therefore to follow after other things than earthly —the character of a man of God, righteousness

things which, in man, presented God to the world glorified Him. Meantime there was conflict: he must fight the good fight of faith. If any one represents God in the world there must be warfare, because the enemy is there, energy of faith was also necessary, in order to enjoy eternal life in the midst of the seduction and difficulty which the "things that are seen" presented. God, however, had called Timothy to this, and he had made: confession before many witnesses. Finally the apostle charges him most solemnly in the presence of God, the source of life for all things, Christ Jesus who had Himself borne witness wavering before the powers of this world, placing under the responsibility of keeping the commandment without spot, unrebukable, until the appearing of our Lord Jesus Christ, It will be noticed here that, as Paul had not spoken in the epistle of the privilege of the Church but responsibility, so neither does he here speak of its being caught up but of its manifestation, when the fruits of it

I TIMOTHY. ch 171

the portion of those for whom it is prepared by His Father, who bestows it according to the work which He has granted each to perform, giving him power to accomplish it (although in grace He reckons it as our own).

Christ Himself is here viewed as the faithful man (ver. 13), whom God will manifest in glory before all creatures at the time ordained in His counsels.

All here is responsibility before the world, or glory as the result of that responsibility. The supreme invisible God is maintained in His majesty, and He presents the Lord Jesus Christ in the creation as their centre, and repository of all His glory—He who dwells in light inaccessible, whom, in His divine essence, man has not seen and cannot see.

This character of the epistle is very remarkable. Nowhere else is the inaccessible majesty of God, as God, thus presented. His character is often the subject of instruction and manifestation. Here He alone has essential immortality. He dwells in inaccessible light. He is ever invisible to the eyes of men. He alone has power. He has dominion over all who reign. It is God in the abstraction of His essence, in the proper immutability of His being, in the rights of His majesty, veiled to all men,

Now Christ will be the centre of the visible glory. Having part in the divine glory before the world was, He displays, in the human nature in which He took part, this glory, which is rendered visible in Him, causing His own to participate in His joy and in all that He has in this character; but here, He is manifested by God, and in order that all should acknowledge

VI.

Him. And it is our responsibility, faithfulness to which will be manifested in that day, which is here set before us. However small may be our share of responsibility it is of such a God as this that we are the representative on earth. Such is the God before whom we are to walk, and whose majesty we are to respect immediately in our conduct, and also in our relations to all that He has made,

The apostle concludes his exhortation to Timothy, engaging him to warn the rich not to rest on the certainty of riches, but on the living God who gives us richly all things to enjoy. It is still the supreme and Creator God who is before our eyes. They were to be rich in good works, and ready to give; (rich in those dispositions which would be of value, which would lay up a store (this is but a figure) against the time to come; and to lay hold of that which really is life, The apostle repeats his urgent exhortation to Timothy to keep that which had been committed to him, to avoid profane and vain babblings, holding fast the sound and a sanctifying truth, and to have nothing to do with oppositions of human science, which pretended to penetrate into divine things as though they were subject to its knowledge. This was the origin of the fall of many with regard to Christian faith.

I do not doubt that, in the manner in which the apostle here sets God before us, he refers to the foolish images of nations to which, under the influence of the enemy, men were abandoning themselves. Thus he speaks of these with relation to the majesty of His Being as the only God in whom is all fulness, and with regard to the

sobriety of practical morality, which keeps the heart under the influence of that truth, and apart from the false and vain speculations in which the pride of man indulged itself. He maintained souls by the majesty of the only God in the practical sobriety in which peace dwells. Soon will the veil be drawn aside by the appearing of Jesus, whom the Almighty God will display to the world.